

Decide the One Thing to Ship Next

The backlog triage Ben Senescu (OpenSEO) ran when sixty pull requests arrived faster than he could safely check them. Works on any backlog AI made cheap to fill: content calendars, client roadmaps, feature lists.

OBJECTIVE

Convert an unbounded backlog into one published direction and one active lane of work, without burning the goodwill of the people who filled the backlog. You end with a roadmap stating the decision *and* the reason, an input channel that still carries signal, and a definition of done you can actually verify. Half a day, repeatable every time the pile rebuilds.

KEY STEPS

1. **Count it honestly and stop pretending you will clear it.** Sixty open PRs on top of ~50 issues. The number is not the problem; believing you will get to it is.
2. **Test each item against verification, not build effort.** "Can I build this" is now always yes. The real question is "if this is subtly wrong, will I find out." Anything failing that is out, however cheap.
3. **Declare bankruptcy publicly, not silently.** Ben posted the update to his community. A quiet mass close reads as abandonment; saying it out loud with the reason reads as a decision. (*inferred: he describes the post; the goodwill framing is why it works.*)
4. **Publish the roadmap that replaces the backlog.** It must exist first, so the "no" has somewhere to point.
5. **Keep the channel that carries signal, close the one that carries cost.** He stopped taking PRs and explicitly kept issues, saying the best contribution now is a well-written issue describing how you want it to work.
6. **Choose a direction and say which.** Horizontal or deep. He chose horizontal on purpose and published it. An unstated direction gets relitigated in every request.
7. **Define done as one thing you can verify.** Not a count of shipped items. If you cannot say how you would notice it breaking, it is not finished.
8. **Re-run when the backlog rebuilds.** It will. This is recurring triage, not a cleanup.

CAUTIONARY NOTES

- "I could build all of it in three weeks" is the trap, not the plan. Slightly-broken everything is unfixable.
- Do not close the channel carrying the signal. Killing issues alongside PRs removes the demand data telling you what to build.
- Silent closure costs more than the backlog did. In a contributing community it reads as the project dying.
- A roadmap without reasons gets argued with. The reason is what stops the request returning next week.
- Not a one-off. The conditions that produced sixty PRs will produce sixty more.

TIPS FOR EFFICIENCY

- Write the roadmap first, then the bankruptcy post. Avoids the gap where people are told no and shown nothing.
- Budget in what you can *verify* per week, not produce per week. That number is smaller and it is the real capacity.
- Keep the roadmap short enough to be read fully. A long one is a backlog in a hat.
- When declining something, name the still-open channel in the same sentence.
- Revisit on a fixed cadence, not when the pile becomes painful. That is always later than it should be.

WHY THIS IS AN SEO PROBLEM TOO

The same thing happened to content. Anyone can now generate more articles, location pages and programmatic variants than they can fact-check, internally link or keep current. The failure mode is identical: not one obvious break, but a hundred things each subtly wrong, arriving faster than anyone can audit them.

"I could probably implement every feature in Semrush in three weeks with Claude Code, but they'd all be so slightly broken that it would just be impossible to fix. I think that's the biggest thing in the AI era, figuring out: I can do anything. What's the one thing I should do?"